

I had wonderful relations with Lighthizer. I can assure you that we have great times ahead in the India-US partnership.

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Are you not worried about tariff hikes?

If it's a tariff hike on China, it only helps India. If it is a tariff hike on everybody, then we are all in the same boat, and we will still continue to do well. I personally believe that India is looked upon as a trusted partner by the democratic world. They want to work with India because of four Ds: In democracy, we have the rule of law; we have demand—1.4 billion aspirational Indians wanting a better quality of life; we have the advantage of demographic dividend, a young population with an average age of 28-29;

we have more STEM graduates than any other country; and, finally, we have decisive leadership. A leadership that can bite the bullet, take bold decisions, and take the country to new heights.

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Speaking of bullets, Trump has been very keen on selling Harley-Davidsons and insisting that we reduce tariffs there...

We would have absolutely no problems. Products where there is no competition... we don't manufacture the Harley-Davidson type of heavy bikes. So I would have absolutely no problem considering a request of that sort. BT

@rahulkanwal

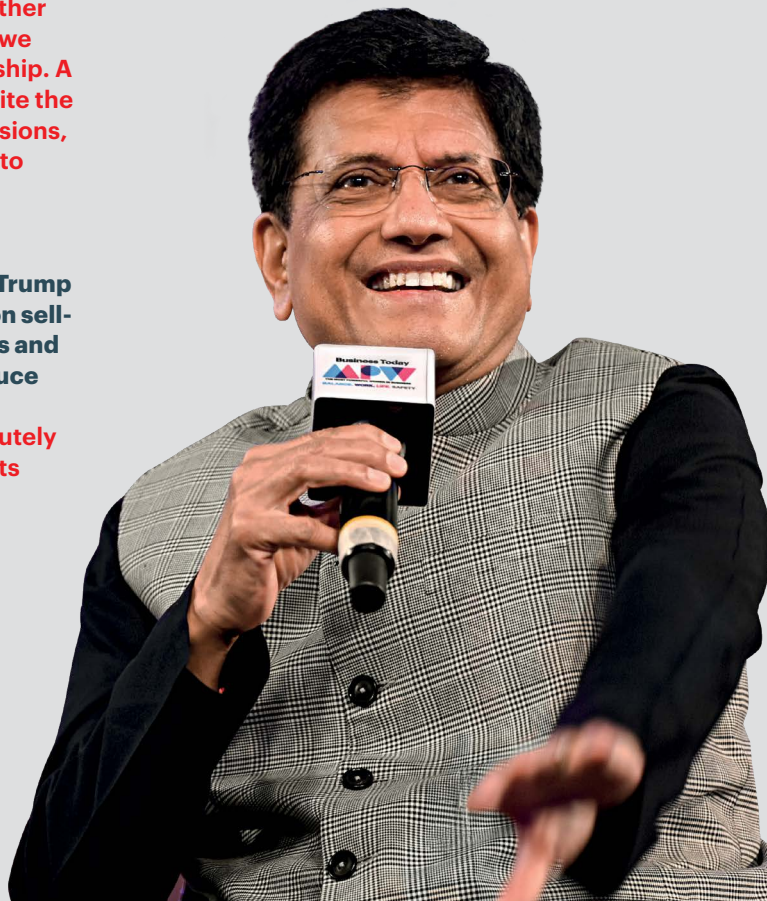


PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE



“India's exports to the US have grown steadily between 2001 and 2023, which coincides with the tenures of four US Presidents”

SUNIL BARTHWAL
COMMERCE SECRETARY,
AT A BRIEFING

is doing well post the monsoon, inflation remains a problem and will continue to impact interest rates. The external situation also remains highly volatile,” says a top finance ministry official.

Capital investments—both public and private—have remained weak this fiscal and officials are hopeful that government capex will pick up in the next few months. However, a recovery in private capex is still far from fruition. According to CareEdge Ratings, the public capex story has largely been subdued in the first half of the fiscal as the central and aggregate state capex contracted by 15.4% YoY and 10.5% YoY, respectively. However, it believes there is a potential for recovery in capex during the remainder of the fiscal. On the corporate capex front, the aggregate capex of a sample set of companies (1,074 non-financial listed companies) was seen at ₹9.4 lakh crore in FY24, mar-